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The other challenge was that WEF was not really an institution. Schwab was the single dominant force in the WEF, and the West spoilt him with access to heads of governments.

Also, after Colette Mathur retired, continuity in the WEF in dealing with India was lacking, seemed transactional and with short memories of all that had been achieved to-

gether. But CII persevered patiently so that India, and Indians, received attention and respect.

The Indian Team: Indian Prime Ministers provided leadership to the Davos opportunity for the country. Perhaps the most dynamic leadership has been provided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi from his time as Chief Minister of Gujarat through to his personal participa-

tion in Davos in 2018 and virtual addresses in 2021 and 2022, during Covid times.

In addition, state Chief Ministers used Davos as an opportunity and platform to bring investments to their jurisdictions, led notably by Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu.

Apart from state leadership, the states also set up their own pavilions at Davos to project the attractions of states for investment. Davos, therefore, formed a key component of India's global economic strategy based on the trusted partnership between the government and industry. This teamwork brought the best results for India.

New Opportunity: The WEF, meanwhile, has gone through its own challenges with Schwab's exit and the installation of a new leadership. There is rethinking across the world about the WEF and new competition is emerging.

However, Davos continues to be important because of the West domination of international institutions, still significant investible resources, technology (especially the US) and continuing commitment to Davos.

However, Asia is the region and the continent for growth. China has its own Boao Forum, but that has not made waves. There is, therefore, a new opportunity for India to build a global forum in Asia but for the world. And, learning from experience, it can be structured differently, be much more inclusive, and way more connected to the Global South.

Conclusion: The story of Davos will continue, and India must be there, but is it also time for a new book to be written centred on Asia? It could even be in partnership with WEF's new leadership, a win-win all around. **BT**

Views are personal